

The Rich Report

U.S. ECONOMICS NEWS

- ◆ **Bond prices:** Par-weighted prices for seven of eight tracked bond indices sat at time-series lows as of September 25, 2026, with yields surging alongside rising rates; only the Morningstar Leveraged Loan Index gained, rising from 96.96 to 97.52 since March 2026.³
- ◆ **Inflation revisions:** Benchmark revisions showed incomes grew faster and inflation rose less than previously estimated; August PCE prices rose 3.4% YoY (core 3.0%) versus a prior-reported 3.7% for July, lowering odds of an October hike though a December hike remains expected.³
- ◆ **GDP growth:** Second-quarter real GDP was revised up to a 2.2% annual rate from 1.5%, with core GDP (consumption, business investment, housing) growing 4.6%, the fastest since 2023, led by a 9.0% annualized rise in business investment tied to AI data-center buildout.³
- ◆ **Factory activity:** The ISM Manufacturing Index slipped to 54.5 in September from 54.6, marking a ninth straight month of expansion even as it posted its second consecutive monthly decline, with new orders rising to 55.3 and order backlogs hitting a seven-month high of 56.4.³
- ◆ **AI imports:** Imports of AI-related hardware — semiconductors, telecom equipment, and computer parts — have risen 102%, 193%, and 216% respectively since 2020, lifting imports' share of "AI investment" to about 35%, up from roughly 20% a few years ago.³
- ◆ **Net AI output:** After subtracting imported equipment, net AI investment (data centers, processing equipment, software, R&D) has flattened since peaking in Q3 2025, even though gross AI spending — about 8% of GDP — has driven more than half of real GDP growth over the past year.³
- ◆ **Jobs report:** September nonfarm payrolls rose just 29,000, far below the 90,000 consensus, with July and August revised down a combined 60,000; the unemployment rate ticked up to 4.2% from 4.1%, though the precise rate moved only marginally to 4.175%.³
- ◆ **Rate-hike timing:** Economists expect the Fed to defer its next hike to December rather than act in late October, partly to avoid politicizing the move ahead of midterm elections, with Atlanta Fed GDPNow projecting 3.7% Q3 growth despite the weak September jobs print.³
- ◆ **Inflation outlook:** Core CPI excluding energy sits at 2.5%, the lowest since 2021, suggesting headline inflation could ease toward that level within six months even without further declines in energy prices, giving the Fed room to hold rates steady near-term.³

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DIGITAL ASSETS NEWS

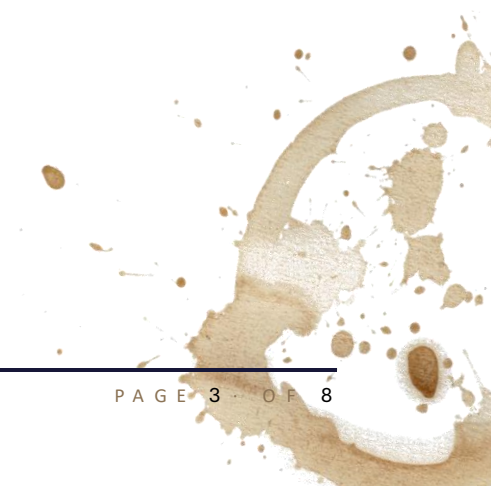
- ◆ **SEC 3x rule:** The SEC approved the first 3x leveraged bitcoin and ether ETFs, letting traders amplify daily price moves threefold within a regulated fund structure. This marks a significant shift in the agency's stance toward crypto derivatives, opening the door to higher-risk, higher-reward exposure for both institutional and retail investors seeking magnified returns.⁵
- ◆ **CLARITY recap:** The CLARITY Act stalled in Congress, leaving comprehensive market-structure legislation unresolved, yet regulators and agencies aren't waiting on lawmakers. New crypto rules and guidance are advancing through existing regulatory channels anyway, signaling that oversight will continue to tighten incrementally even without a unified legislative framework defining clear jurisdictional lines between the SEC and CFTC.⁵
- ◆ **Blockchain.com IPO:** Crypto wallet and exchange platform Blockchain.com is reportedly preparing a U.S. IPO that could raise roughly \$500 million, valuing the company at up to \$6 billion. The listing would mark one of the sector's most prominent public debuts, capitalizing on improving regulatory clarity and renewed investor appetite for crypto-linked offerings.⁵
- ◆ **Goldman Treasury:** Goldman Sachs integrates its \$100 billion Treasury fund into institutional crypto infrastructure, enabling tokenized money-market shares to serve as collateral within digital asset platforms. The move signals growing convergence between traditional fixed-income vehicles and blockchain-based settlement systems, offering institutional clients faster collateral mobility while deepening Wall Street's footprint in crypto market infrastructure.⁵

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GEOPOLITICS NEWS

- ◆ **Argentina:** President Milei is positioning Argentina as a regulation-free haven for artificial intelligence, telling the UN General Assembly the country will not preemptively regulate AI. His team openly uses AI-generated influencers for political messaging, reflecting a broader hands-off governmental stance even as Western leaders and tech CEOs increasingly push for AI guardrails.¹
- ◆ **Iran:** Middle East crude exports rebounded to nearly 13 million barrels a day this month, close to prewar levels, as the US Navy and Gulf producers improved defenses against Iranian attacks in the Strait of Hormuz, easing pressure on global oil markets despite continued Iranian strikes on tankers.¹
- ◆ **Iran:** Tehran confirmed receiving an official US response to its latest proposal to end the seven-month war, days after Trump publicly rejected an earlier offer. President Pezeshkian called for a “win-win” agreement as Qatari and Pakistani mediators continue facilitating indirect talks.¹
- ◆ **Japan:** PM Takaichi raised permanent residency fees 2,000%, to \$1,271 from \$64, alongside stricter income, pension and language requirements, citing rising public anxiety over an immigration and tourism influx driven by a weak yen and labor shortages.¹
- ◆ **Russia:** Russia launched its heaviest combined strike on Ukraine’s energy grid in months, hitting Kyiv-area power plants and killing seven, as PM Koretskyi warned of an intensifying winter campaign aimed at plunging Ukrainian cities into cold and darkness.¹
- ◆ **Russia:** Moscow’s new budget locks in record war spending for three years, with 2027 outlays set near 17 trillion rubles and only slight declines through 2028, funded by new windfall taxes on mining and metals firms as energy revenue weakens and the deficit nears 2% of GDP.¹



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THE GOOD NEWS

- ◆ **Nuclear reactor:** The Nuclear Regulatory Commission approved the Tennessee Valley Authority's construction permit for a small modular reactor at Clinch River, only the second next-generation commercial reactor ever approved in the US. TVA is weighing up to four reactors there, designed to be cheaper and faster to build than traditional plants.²
- ◆ **Life expectancy:** Life expectancy across the Americas hit 77.1 years in 2023, exceeding the pre-pandemic 2019 peak of 76.7 years, according to regional health data. Healthy life expectancy — years lived in good health — also rose, though at a slower pace, signaling a durable post-COVID recovery.²
- ◆ **AI safety:** Nvidia unveiled the Open Agent Safety Platform, pairing its OpenShell software with a new monitoring system called Sentry that runs on dedicated hardware separate from the AI's processor. This independent layer can detect and quarantine misbehaving AI agents within milliseconds, strengthening containment as autonomous agents spread.²
- ◆ **Car theft:** Vehicle thefts in the US fell 21% in the first half of 2026 compared to a year earlier, with all 50 states posting declines, per the National Insurance Crime Bureau. Roughly 268,000 thefts were reported, continuing a multi-year downward trend in auto crime nationwide.²

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DIVIDEND PORTFOLIO NEWS

- ◆ **ABT:** Abbott launched “SimpleScreen,” a new blood test aimed at expanding early cancer screening access, broadening its diagnostics portfolio.⁴
- ◆ **CAT:** Caterpillar announced a \$1 billion North Carolina manufacturing expansion alongside a deal to acquire Fabick dealership operations, strengthening domestic production capacity and distribution reach as industrial demand remains a focus.⁴
- ◆ **CEG:** Constellation Energy signed a 20-year nuclear power agreement with Amazon to supply data centers, reinforcing its leadership in nuclear-backed clean energy contracts.⁴
- ◆ **LMT:** Lockheed Martin secured a wave of contracts: \$297M and \$724M Navy/missile defense deals, a \$6B missile-propulsion award to L3Harris, and helped the Navy double MQ-25A drone capacity. Its F-35 began permanent Finland deployment, though Boeing won a separate \$20B stealth jet contract.⁴
- ◆ **NEE:** NextEra Energy and partners were selected to develop a \$22 billion Texas power plant specifically to serve data center demand, positioning the company to capture growing electricity needs tied to AI infrastructure buildout.⁴
- ◆ **NTR:** Nutrien announced the permanent closure of its Trinidad nitrogen operations, a move likely reflecting cost rationalization amid challenging nitrogen fertilizer market dynamics and regional competitiveness pressures.⁴
- ◆ **QCOM:** Qualcomm reached a multi-year patent licensing agreement with Huawei, resolving a key IP dispute, while separately returning to court against Arm over contract terms.⁴
- ◆ **SPGI:** S&P Global declared a \$0.97 quarterly dividend, extended its exclusive index-licensing agreement with Cboe by 25 years, and launched a new risk assessment tool for digital asset custody vaults, expanding its data and ratings franchise.⁴

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GROWTH PORTFOLIO NEWS

- ◆ **CVX:** Chevron promoted its CFO to lead oil and gas operations, a move seen as positioning for potential CEO succession and signaling continuity in strategy amid a strong Q3 for the energy sector.⁴
- ◆ **FCX:** Freeport-McMoRan hit its Q3 copper production targets even as copper futures headed for a weekly loss; separately, Chile's copper output sank to a 15-year low, tightening global supply.⁴
- ◆ **FTNT:** Google expanded its Gemini Enterprise AI platform with cybersecurity tools from major vendors including Fortinet, reinforcing Fortinet's role in enterprise AI-security integration.⁴
- ◆ **HOOD:** Robinhood shares rose after launching new active-trading products and a BlackSky satellite-imagery partnership for its agent app. The stock was among September's top financial performers, while reports highlighted its push into 24/7 tokenized stock trading.⁴
- ◆ **KEYS:** Keysight Technologies is set to unveil new AI-focused test and measurement products next month, positioning the company to capture rising demand tied to AI infrastructure buildouts.⁴
- ◆ **TSM:** TSMC is reportedly weighing new Texas investment to expand U.S. chip production, while Wells Fargo flagged its 2nm ramp as a boon for equipment suppliers; upcoming earnings seen as a key market test.⁴
- ◆ **VST:** Vistra is set to receive a \$4 billion U.S. government loan to boost nuclear power production, reinforcing its position in supplying energy for AI-driven data center growth.⁴

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SUMMARY

In regard to the United States Economy, benchmark revisions showed inflation rose less and incomes grew more than previously thought, with August core PCE at 3.0%. Second-quarter GDP was revised up to 2.2%, led by a 9.0% jump in business investment tied to AI data centers, though trade subtracted 1.1 points. Factory activity extended its expansion streak, while September payrolls disappointed at 29,000 and unemployment rose to 4.2%, keeping a December rate hike likely.

In the world of digital assets, the SEC approved the first 3x leveraged bitcoin and ether ETFs, opening regulated access to amplified crypto exposure. The CLARITY Act stalled in Congress, but regulators keep tightening oversight through existing channels. Blockchain.com is reportedly preparing a U.S. IPO valuing it near \$6 billion, while Goldman Sachs integrated its \$100 billion Treasury fund into crypto infrastructure, letting tokenized money-market shares serve as collateral on digital asset platforms.

Recently around the globe, Argentina's Milei pitched the country as a regulation-free AI haven at the UN, even as Western leaders push for guardrails. Middle East crude exports rebounded near prewar levels as naval defenses improved, while Iran confirmed receiving a US response to its latest ceasefire proposal. Japan sharply raised residency fees amid immigration anxiety, and Russia launched its heaviest strike in months on Ukraine's grid while locking in record war spending.

For the good news, the NRC approved TVA's construction permit for a small modular reactor at Clinch River, only the second next-generation reactor ever cleared in the US. Life expectancy across the Americas climbed to 77.1 years, surpassing pre-pandemic levels. Nvidia unveiled a new AI safety platform capable of quarantining misbehaving agents within milliseconds, and US vehicle thefts fell 21% in early 2026, with every state posting declines.

In the news for the dividend portfolio, Abbott launched a new early-cancer blood test while medtech stocks lagged broader healthcare gains. Caterpillar announced a \$1 billion North Carolina expansion and a Fabick dealership acquisition. Constellation Energy signed a 20-year nuclear supply deal with Amazon, standing out amid utility sector weakness. Lockheed Martin secured a wave of defense contracts, while NextEra was tapped for a \$22 billion Texas plant serving data centers.

And, for the growth portfolio, Chevron promoted its CFO in an apparent succession move, while Freeport-McMoRan hit copper targets as Chile's output hit a 15-year low. Robinhood shares rose on new trading products and a satellite-imagery partnership, and Keysight prepped new AI-focused test equipment. Nvidia dominated headlines with raised price targets and major financing deals tied to AI chip demand, while Vistra is set to receive a \$4 billion loan for nuclear power.

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RESOURCES

- ◆ Research accumulated from <https://www.patreon.com/cw/PeterZeihan>, <https://x.com/>, and <https://seekingalpha.com/>
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